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The Influence of Employee Involvement Program Membership During Downsizing: Attitudes Toward the Employer and the Union

Christopher L. Martin
Louisiana State University in Shreveport

Charles K. Parsons
Georgia Institute of Technology

Nathan Bennett
Louisiana State University at Baton Rouge

This study investigates the influence of employee involvement (EI) program membership on attitudes towards an organization, its management, and the union during organizational downsizing. Respondents were 147 union members who had been notified of their discharge from a large manufacturer. EI membership had significant effects on worker commitment to the organization, attitudes towards management, perceived fairness and attributions of blame, but not on attitudes toward the union. However, EI members did place somewhat greater blame for the layoff on the union.

Responding to intense competitive pressures, many organizations have adopted team-based employee involvement (EI) programs (e.g., Quality Circles, Total Quality Management, Quality of Work Life Committees), with the belief that such programs will lead to increased productivity and cost reductions (Blinder, 1989; Lawler & Mohrman, 1985, 1987; Meyer & Scott, 1985). Although such programs have been directed toward solving job-related quality problems and improving methods of production, research has linked participation in EI programs to a variety of other positive employee behaviors and attitudes. For example, participation has been tied to increased levels of satisfaction and organizational commitment (Cotton, Vollrath, Froggatt, Lengnick-Hall & Jennings, 1988; Griffin & Bateman, 1986) and has been found to facilitate communication within groups and commitment to organizational goals (Locke & Schweiger, 1979). Such programs have also been found to lead to improved working conditions, and to provide greater opportunities for employee input and self-development (Lawler, 1986).

Direct all correspondence to: Christopher L. Martin, Louisiana State University, Department of Management and Marketing, Shreveport, LA 71115. e-mail <SHCMAR @ LSUVM.sncc.LSU.edu>.

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In recent empirical evaluations of these programs, the focus has been on organizational or employee outcomes such as productivity, absenteeism, quality of work life, organizational and union commitment, and job satisfaction (Griffin, 1988; Marks, Mirvis, Hackett & Grady, 1986; Mellor, 1992). A possible additional benefit of EI program membership which has yet to be investigated concerns the role that membership may have as a source of support during threatening organizational changes. Marks et al. (1986) found that EI program members, who were exposed to the same negative organizational changes as non-members, suffered less of a drop in quality-of-work-life attitudes. An indirect asset of EI programs may be that the teams provided a forum in which employees could receive clarification regarding changes, as well as distinguish facts from rumors. Marks et al. (1986) suggest that membership may therefore have been a source of informational support that buffered members' negative attitudinal response to potentially threatening changes. The purpose of this paper is to directly test this proposition in a sample of employees scheduled for a layoff. The focal research question is then how specifically does EI program membership affect the work attitudes of employees who learn they will soon be permanently laid off?

As corporations downsize, the possibility of layoff is perhaps the most ominous change facing workers. The downsizing literature (Cameron, Whetten & Kim, 1987; Wheeler, Gray, Giacobbe & Quick, 1990) suggests that employees' work behaviors and attitudes about employers erode once they are notified of impending layoffs. Past research has focused primarily on the reactions of layoff survivors (i.e., those who remain employed with the downsized organization, Brockner & Greenberg, 1990). However, as a consequence of the extended warning provisions of the Worker Adjustment and Retraining Notification (WARN) Act of 1988, individuals remain in their jobs and are expected to perform their tasks and duties for a significant amount of time after learning they will be laid off. Research has found decreases in employee morale, loyalty, commitment, innovation, and participation are commonly observed after layoff notification (Leana & Feldman, 1992). While these victim reactions are costly to the organization, there is also the likelihood that these victims, now disgruntled, will also undesirably influence the reactions of layoff survivors (Brockner, 1988). For these two reasons, understanding the job-related attitudes and behaviors of layoff victims after notification is critical (Bies, Martin & Brockner, 1993; Martin & Bies, 1991).

Research has demonstrated that perceptions of the fairness of a layoff have an important impact on survivors' continued attitudes toward the employer (Bies, Martin & Brockner, 1993; Brockner, 1988; Brockner & Greenberg, 1990). In all, research suggests that "appearing fair" prevents an erosion of employee morale and commitment. Judgments of fair treatment during a layoff are not simply based on distributive fairness concerns of whether or not a particular employee received a desired outcome (i.e., did they keep their job). Fairness judgments greatly depend on both the procedures used (cf. Leventhal, 1980; Thibaut & Walker, 1975) and the interpersonal treatment afforded individuals during layoff implementation (cf. Bies & Moag, 1986; Tyler & Bies, 1990). For

example, did management offer an adequate explanation of the reasons for the layoff? An emphasis on interpersonal communication during the implementation of organizational procedures is the gist of interactional justice (Bies & Moag, 1986).

Consistent with other research on communication and its role in developing perceptions of fairness (Bies, 1987; Folger & Martin, 1986), Bies et al. (1993) found employee perceptions of fairness were enhanced when "bad news" such as layoff notification was delivered with adequate, open, and truthful communication. Indeed, Bies et al. (1993) determined that layoff victims focused more on the interpersonal treatment they received during layoff implementation than on distributive issues or the structural characteristics of procedures, such as voice and appeal mechanisms. Since such communication is likely facilitated through EI programs (Fitzgerald & Murphy, 1982), membership may ameliorate workers' negative reactions to the layoff. Based on these points, we hypothesize:

> **H1A**: *After notification of their layoff, victims who have been members of EI programs will report higher levels of fairness of the layoff process than non-members.*
>
> **H1B**: *After notification of their layoff, victims who have been members of EI programs will report higher levels of organizational commitment than non-members.*

Leana and Feldman (1992) have analyzed attributional processes layoff victims use to affix blame in an layoff context. Leana and Feldman (1988) propose that victims of large scale work force reductions or plant closings will attribute job loss to factors outside of their control rather than to themselves, because in such cases, incompetence is not implied by termination. Indeed, frustrations and anxieties of organizational decline are frequently blamed on management, because of its failure to protect employees from pain or to arrest decline (Krantz, 1985). Alternatively, the emphasis on individualism in our culture has been thought to be a potential impetus for the unemployed to blame themselves (Newman, 1988). However, in their research, Leana and Feldman (1992) found that individuals engaged in little self-blame, with most blame targeted at management incompetence. Since EI programs include employees in the management process and expose them to the circumstances of the decline, they could be expected to lead employees to place less blame for the layoff on management. Thus, we hypothesize:

> **H2A**: *After notification of their layoff, victims who have been members of EI programs will report more pro-management attitudes than non-members.*
>
> **H2B**: *After notification of their layoff, victims who have been members of EI programs will place less blame for the layoff on management than will non-members.*

By building commitment to the employer, group-based participation programs, such as EI programs, may erode support for the union (Griffin & Bateman, 1986; Perline & Poynter, 1989; Verma, 1989). Recently, several national unions have labeled "team concept" programs as an attempt to drain unions of their power, in fact calling them one of the "most serious dangers facing unions" (IAM, 1990, p. 1). However, most research investigating the relationship between EI programs and attitudes towards unions and management has found that as involvement increases, so do favorable opinions of both unions and management (Griffin, 1988; Bies et al., 1993; Sherer & Morishima, 1989).

Because of the equivocality of the literature addressing EI membership and attitudes towards unions, we do not formulate a specific hypothesis. It is important, however, to learn more about whether EI programs may increase blame attributed to a union during a layoff. At least one study has found that lower levels of union commitment were reported by members who believed management accounts blaming the union for layoffs (Mellor, 1992). Therefore, we explore the relationship between EI membership and layoff victims' attitudes concerning the union.

Method

Research Site

The research site was a large (N=2,400), unionized manufacturing facility located in an "open shop" state. The plant was part of a multinational corporation with over 280,000 employees worldwide. Each of the corporation's manufacturing plants bid against one another to retain their current product line and win new product contracts. To compete profitably in the global marketplace, all of the corporation's U.S. facilities were forced to cut costs, delivery times, and employees, while maintaining quality. In 1986, the EI concept was introduced by plant management as a means to aggressively manage costs and quality, and as an evolutionary step toward self-managing work teams.

Over the next four years, top management randomly selected teams throughout the plant for inclusion in the EI program. By the end of the fourth year, over 55% of the total non-management work force were EI program members. Teams met for one hour each week and were led by team supervisors. Trained facilitators coordinated the overall program and provided support for the teams. This included in-depth training as to the process and philosophy of EI, selecting group projects, and applying productivity and quality improvement tools.

As specified in the organization's EI material, the agenda for teams was: to enhance and open employee communication; set and meet challenging goals; meet commitments to customers as well as in individual and group performance; activate employee participation/empowerment; move decision making and accountability to appropriate levels; reduce product costs; develop teamwork with internal and external partners; and continuously improve both people and operations.

Three months prior to our study, a sample (N=1,340) of employees was surveyed by plant management, giving employees an opportunity to voluntarily provide their assessment of the EI process. Responses were received from 1,032 employees (77% response rate); approximately sixty percent of the respondents were EI members. On virtually all goals associated with the EI program, large numbers of employees felt there had been significant progress since the process was launched (e.g., responded "greatly" or "somewhat" improved to items addressing housekeeping, 91%; product throughput time, 83%; customer satisfaction, 77%; design for manufacturing, 75%; setting objectives and following through, 70%). Least improved was union/management relations (37% answering "greatly" or "somewhat"). Although no exact figure was available in terms of cost savings generated by the EI program, two years prior to this survey the facility was named one of the 10 most productive facilities in the country by a leading business magazine. One month following the in-house EI survey, the corporation pulled a product line from the plant site and awarded it to an overseas manufacturing facility. This resulted in the permanent layoff of 210 skilled trade employees. The layoff victims were informed in writing that this was to be a permanent layoff with no chance of a recall.

Respondents and Procedures

The study was conducted approximately two months after the announcement of the layoff and one month before the respondents' termination. During organizational "exit interviews", those scheduled for layoff (N=210) were told of a university sponsored study on the victims of layoffs. Employees who wished to participate (N=147, 70%) were then escorted by the principal investigator to a conference room, where they each completed the questionnaire.

In comparing those who responded with those left unsurveyed, no significant differences in demographic characteristics (i.e., age, sex, race, tenure, education) or proportion of employees participating in the EI program was found. Sixty-five percent of the respondents were white, 33% black, and 2% other race; 24% were male. As the layoff was seniority based, all affected employees had been with the employer for between 16 and 17 years. Seventy-two percent of the respondents were EI program members. Those laid off held positions across the plant, not just with the lost product line. All of those laid off were dues-paying members of the union.

This sample provides a distinct advantage over earlier studies of EI programs. Since workers were assigned to EI teams, there is no danger of the self-selection bias present in earlier studies where workers volunteered to participate. That is, response differences between EI members and non-members are unlikely to be explained by characteristics of those who happen to volunteer to participate in EI (cf. Leana, Ahlbrandt & Murrell, 1992).

Measures

EI program membership. Respondents were asked on the survey "Are you a member of a quality team?" The responses were then verified through

organizational records, and no discrepancy was found. This variable was dummy coded (0,1) such that a "1" indicated EI membership (N=107).

Organizational commitment. Organizational commitment was measured through 4 questions adopted from the O'Reilly and Chatman (1986) instrument (α=.89). The questions focused on psychological attachment to the organization based on identification ("I'm proud to tell others, I'm a part of this organization; "I talk up this organization as a great place to work) and internalization ("The reason I prefer this organization to others is because of what it stands for—its values"; "Since joining this organization, my personal values and those of the organization have become more similar"). Responses were on a 7 point scale anchored by "strongly disagree" and "strongly agree," coded such that a high score indicates a high level of organizational commitment.

Attitudes toward management and union. Three questions tapped the respondent feelings concerning the local plant management: "How favorable do you feel toward local plant management?;" "To what extent does local plant management know what they're doing?;" "I trust local plant management." Responses were on a 7-point scale anchored by "strongly disagree" and "strongly agree." The three items were summed to form a composite with a coefficient alpha of .82. Attitude towards the union was assessed through an identical set of three questions, substituting "union" in place of "local plant management." The coefficient alpha was .85 for the union composite. For both measures, high scores indicate favorable attitudes towards the target group.

Perceived fairness. Four questions (α=.85) tapped the measure of *adequate explanation* ("To what extent did local plant management give you enough details in their explanation of this layoff;" "How clearly were the reasons for this layoff explained to you by (a) local management, (b) corporate management; "To what degree did local management give you their explanation for this layoff?"). Three questions (α=.75) tapped the degree of *open and honest communication* present ("To what extent (a) were things brought out in the open without hiding them from employees, (b) was there adequate two-way communication between management and labor, (c) was management honest and upright in dealing with employees?"). Responses were on a 7-point scale ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree." Each of these items reflects the emphasis on communication central to the interactional justice dimension identified by Bies and Moag (1986). Again, the scale is coded so that a high score reflects high perceived fairness.

Blame. Blame for the respondent's layoff was assessed by means of single-item measures ("Management (The union) is to blame for this layoff"). In addition to blame attributed to management and the union, the study included an item assessing the degree to which individuals blamed themselves for the layoff ("I blame myself and others like me for the layoff"). Responses were on a 7-point scale ranging from "strongly disagree" to "strongly agree," such that a high score reflects high blame.

Results

Table 1 shows the intercorrelations, means, and standard deviations for all variables. It should be noted that the strength of the association between EI membership and the other variables may be understated, as point-biserial correlations are restricted when the groups are of unequal proportion (Nunnally, 1976). EI membership was positively associated with organizational commitment and attitudes toward local management. There is a weak, positive correlation between EI membership and the attribution that employees themselves were responsible for the layoff. However, the mean level of attribution was very low (x=1.41 on a 7 point scale), indicating that the employees felt quite strongly that they were not responsible for the layoff. Pairwise t-tests among the three blame measures resulted in significant mean differences such that blame placed on management was greater than that placed on the union (t=7.39, $p<.001$); the union, in turn, received more blame than individuals assigned to themselves (t=11.86, $p<.001$).

Several other patterns in Table 1 are also noteworthy. First, attitude toward the union was positively related to attitudes toward local management (r=.44, $p<.01$). This suggests some congruence between beliefs about trust and competence of the union and management. Second, the amount of self-blame is positively correlated with EI membership and favorable opinions of local plant management. Third, reports of poor explanation are associated with the amount of blame placed on the union (r=−.17, $p<.05$). Finally, the general attitude toward local management was associated with the variable attributing blame to local management (r=−.38, $p<.01$), and the general attitude toward the union was most strongly associated with the variable attributing blame to the union (r=−.49, $p<.01$). This suggests that workers were maintaining some cognitive consistency between their general feelings toward these groups and their attribution of blame.

The following procedure was used to test the hypotheses. First, because of intercorrelations among the dependent variables (Mean r=.23), a multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) was conducted. Based on a significant F for that analysis (Wilks L = .88; $F_{8,121}$=2.15, $p<.05$), follow-up analyses of variance (ANOVA) were performed to explore mean differences in the dependent variables based on employee EI membership status. The results of the ANOVAs are presented in Table 2.

H1A predicted that discharged EI program members would have more favorable impressions than discharged non-members of the perceived fairness of the layoff. This hypothesis is supported, as EI members reported greater perceptions of open communication (F=6.99, $p<.01$) and adequate explanation for the layoff (F=2.74, $p<.05$). **H1B** predicted that discharged employees who were also EI members would report higher levels of organizational commitment than non-members. This hypothesis received support, as well (F=4.00, $p<.05$).

H2A, which predicted that EI members would report more favorable attitudes towards management, was supported (F=5.44, $p<.05$). No significant difference in attitudes towards the union based on EI membership was found

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics and Zero-Order Correlations[a]

	$\bar{x}$	*sd*	*1*	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*	*9*
1. EI program member	.73	.45	—								
2. Organizational commitment	14.94	7.24	.17	.86							
3. Attitude towards union	9.10	5.24	-.07	.16	.84						
4. Attitude towards local management	8.54	5.19	.20	.47	.44	.83					
5. Communication	9.36	4.89	.22	.50	.31	.71	.75				
6. Explanation	8.83	4.11	.14	.24	.31	.41	.45	.71			
7. Blame management	4.19	2.53	-.15	-.25	-.15	-.38	-.31	-.23	—		
8. Blame union	2.97	2.33	.12	-.07	-.49	-.16	-.14	-.17	.12	—	
9. Blame self	1.41	1.30	.17	.10	-.00	.18	.05	.02	.02	.13	—

Notes: a. $n = 147$. Diagonal reports alpha for multi-item measures. A correlation of .17 is significant with $p < .05$, of .22 with $p < .01$, two-tailed tests.

Table 2. Results of Analysis of Variance for EI Program Membership and Employee Attitudes[a]

	EI Program Membership		
Dependent Variables	*Member* $\bar{x}$	*Non-member* $\bar{x}$	*F*
Communication	9.99	7.63	6.99**
Explanation	9.25	7.97	2.74*
Organizational commitment	15.62	12.89	4.00*
Attitude towards union	8.86	9.66	.65
Attitude towards local management	9.12	6.89	5.44*
Blame management	3.96	4.82	3.25*
Blame union	3.18	2.56	1.87†
Blame self	1.45	1.03	3.86*

Notes: a. $n = 147$.
† $p < .10$;
* $p < .05$;
** $p < .01$

in an exploratory analysis (F=.65, ns). Finally, **H2B** predicted that discharged EI members would place less blame for the layoff on management. Indeed, this was the case (F=3.25, p<.05). The analysis indicates that EI members were somewhat *more* likely to blame the union (F=1.87, p<.10). In an additional analysis, EI members were found to place more blame on themselves (F=3.86, p<.05) for the impending layoff.

Discussion

This study represents an initial examination of how participation in EI programs affects reactions to a layoff and victims' feelings toward the union and management. In all, our findings point to effects of EI programs beyond those typically identified. The study suggests that EI membership does make a difference in worker responses to being discharged. Despite the fact that they faced permanent layoff, EI members reported higher levels of organizational commitment and more favorable attitudes towards management than non-members faced with the same outcome.

EI members, as compared to non-members, reported there was better communication about the layoff. These findings are consistent with those reported by Bies et al. (1993) in that poor outcomes are better received when communicated in a considerate, respectful manner. In all, interactional justice was significantly and positively associated with evaluations of management and commitment to the organization. To the extent that EI membership serves as a vehicle for affecting judgments of interactional fairness, this suggests another beneficial consequence of such programs.

As noted earlier, some unions have been opposed to group-based work innovations, fearing that participation techniques may cause workers to side with management on controversial issues. Our findings suggest that this fear may be justified in that EI membership had an impact on where layoff victims

placed blame. As compared to non-members, EI members were less severe in their assignment of blame to management and more severe in their assignment of blame to the union and themselves. In conjunction with the finding that EI membership did not result in mean differences in attitudes toward the union, this suggests that EI processes affected members' attributional processes but not their evaluation of the union. Finally, the finding that union blame was greater among employees who reported lower evaluations of interactional justice may indicate some employees felt that the union was not doing its part to pressure management for adequate explanation.

Two points regarding attributions of blame are of particular interest. First, self-blame was highest among victims who held high opinions of management and reported high levels of organizational commitment. Perhaps individuals who hold their employer in high regard cannot tolerate the cognitive dissonance that would result from attributing blame for a layoff to management. Second, EI membership was associated with individuals' evaluations of management's role and their own roles in causing the layoff. The finding that EI members ascribed more blame to themselves and fellow workers than did non-members suggests that the involvement that comes through EI participation increases felt responsibility for the organization's success (or failure). In other words, members may have felt that they "should have seen it coming" and been able to do something preemptive. However, it should be re-emphasized that both EI members and non-members attributed little blame to themselves relative to the other targets.

Certain limitations to the study should be noted, to correctly frame these results and also stimulate future research on this topic. Because the data were all collected from a single plant, the findings do not necessarily generalize to other organizations. For instance, if the union had opposed the EI concept, we might have seen an entirely different set of results. Investigations of the relationships we considered in different organizational contexts is clearly warranted.

We could not address how individuals differed in regard to their degree of involvement in the EI process. Though anecdotal evidence suggests that participation was generally the norm, EI members were not necessarily committed to the EI concept, as they typically are in studies where membership is voluntary. In this plant, workers were told to, at a minimum, attend and not disrupt sessions. This acts to make our tests of EI membership conservative, in that some members may be hostile to EI. As a result, it may be more difficult to demonstrate an effect for EI membership.

Regardless, future research should consider how the duration of EI involvement or amount of commitment to EI influences employees' attitudes towards employers and unions. Of particular interest may be the role of perceived organizational support (cf. Eisenberg, Fasolo & Davis-LaMastro, 1990; Eisenberg, Huntington, Hutchinson & Sowa, 1986; Shore & Wayne, 1993) as a precursor to EI involvement. One consequence of perceived organizational support is thought to be the development of an "evaluation bias" that influences individuals' judgments about employers (Eisenberg et al., 1990). Research on

this concept in an EI context would provide further understanding of the mechanism through which involvement affects employees' views of employers.

Finally, these findings have some interesting implications for justice research due, in large part, to the context in which this study took place. Layoff victims are in an intriguing position with regard to justice. Their outcome, job loss, is distributively poor. Many of the structural aspects of procedural justice (e.g., voice, appeal mechanisms) are not typically available to layoff victims. In all, the only source of fairness they can likely access involves the quality of the interpersonal treatment they receive from their employer (Bies et al., 1993). Given the importance of fairness perceptions to both layoff survivors and victims, further study of interactional justice and of the role that EI plays as a conduit for evidence of fair treatment is clearly warranted.

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